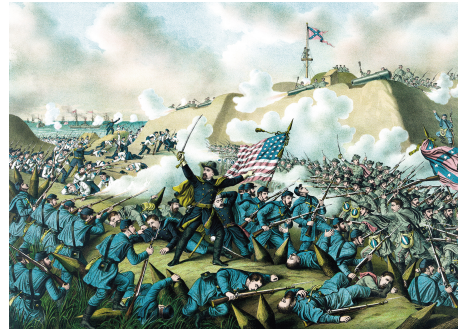


KEY MOMENT

THE FALL OF FORT FISHER

By late 1864, Wilmington, North Carolina, was the only major port through which overseas supplies were still reaching the Confederate armies. It was protected from attack by Fort Fisher, a massive log-and-earth bastion at the mouth of the Cape Fear River, defended by 47 guns, 22 facing the ocean and 25 facing the land.

On January 15, 1865, a fleet under Admiral David D. Porter bombarded the fort from the sea, while the troops of General Alfred H. Terry attacked from the land. Under these two men, a combined force of 6,500 Union soldiers and sailors took the fort in a single day, with battle raging into the night. At 10 p.m. the Confederates under General W. H. C. Whiting surrendered to General Terry. The Union forces had taken the garrison with 2,000 men inside. Wilmington itself fell soon, leaving the Southern heartland cut off from trade with foreign countries.



Confederate strategy

General Sherman had split his troops into two columns, and Johnston's only realistic hope lay in attacking the splintered Union forces. The Confederates attempted to delay one of the two columns outside the village of Averasboro before launching a fully fledged attack on the Federal left wing at Bentonville, barely a day's march south of Goldsboro.

The initial Confederate successes were soon countered by the arrival of Union reinforcements, and Sherman was able to rendezvous successfully with Schofield on March 23.

The Alabama campaign

Meanwhile, Union leaders had devised a two-pronged strategy to carry the war into Alabama. One force under General E. R. S. Canby was sent to invade the state from the south through lower Mobile Bay, which had been occupied by Union forces after a naval battle the previous August. Canby succeeded in taking the city of Mobile itself in April 1865. In the meantime, a 27-year-old cavalry commander, James H. Wilson, led a mounted troop of 13,000 men